Taaffeite

△ **Cushion-cut** taaffeite

When a mineralogist or gemologist hears of the discovery of a new and previously unknown gemstone, his or her thoughts go to a seam of rock in a distant mountain range, or the gravels of a stream or river flowing through some exotic jungle. Rarely do their thoughts go to a jeweller's shop in Dublin, Ireland. Yet this is precisely where taaffeite was discovered by Richard Taaffe in 1945 among a number of faceted gems recovered from old jewellery. It is one of the rarest gemstones, and is cut exclusively for collectors.

Specification

Chemical name Beryllium, magnesium, and aluminium oxide **Formula** $BeMg_3Al_8O_{16}$ | **Colours** Pale mauve, green, sapphire blue | **Structure** Hexagonal | **Hardness** 8–8.5 | **SG** 3.60–3.62 | **RI** 1.71–1.73 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** White **Locations** Sri Lanka, Tanzania, China

Raw gem | **Rough** | This water-rounded crystal of taaffeite rough has a "window" polished into one end so the cutter can assess its clarity.

Lavender colour | **Colour variety** | The pale, almost transparent, mauve colour for which the gemstone is best known is displayed in this brilliant-cut oval cushion specimen.

Pentagonal taaffeite | **Cut** | This 8.5-carat taaffeite is exceptionally large and is faceted in a pentagonal step-cut with a rich plum colour.

Taaffeite is the only gemstone in history to have been identified from a stone that had already been faceted

Cut taaffeite gemstone | **Cut** | Even a relatively simple brilliant cut has extra sparkle and "fire" due to the taaffeite's double refraction, as seen here.

Extraordinary colour | **Colour variety** | This 1.23-carat oval stone has a highly unusual bright purplish-red colour and features a brilliant-cut crown.